In 2000, Tata Motors (or TELCO, as it was called then) was known mostly as a producer of trucks, although it had successfully launched the Indica in 1998. The Nano was an altogether new concept and a gargantuan project that he challenged himself to make a success of.

There are many stories associated with the Nano and how the idea of a people's car took root in Ratan's mind. The popular narrative is that he was moved to make road journeys safer for middle-class citizens after he saw a family of four, including two children, on a scooter on the rain-drenched roads of Mumbai. But the car itself took shape during a 'boring' board meeting. When he was bored at long meetings, Ratan would usually preoccupy himself by sketching, drawing and doodling, from which emanated several of his business ideas. As he said at a JRD QV Award function in 2008, he 'spent a lot of time dwelling on how to make the scooter safer, building a frame around it, putting a roof around it'. He added that it was 'perhaps my most constructive doodle' as from that germinated the idea of the Nano. Could a car be designed for a family that can only afford a scooter, he mulled?

The idea stuck. Ratan put together an exploratory team of young engineers in 2003 to begin working on the concept. In March, as was his practice, Ratan attended the Geneva Motor Show. At the expo, he could not resist the temptation of revealing that he was working on the blueprint of a small car called the Nano. He told John Griffiths of the *Financial Times*, 'It is my dream, to make the car a reality within … five years.'

What would be the possible cost of such a car, Griffiths asked. Ratan replied that it would be around Rs 1 lakh. It was just a random number; the price of the car had not been fixed at the time. But it stuck and would go on to become the bane of the innovation by giving it the tag of a 'cheap car'. The next day, the newspaper headline spoke of Ratan's project of a 'Rs 1-lakh car'. 'The press hijacked it and turned it into the world's cheapest car,' recalls Noel Tata.

Ratan had not bargained for the extensive coverage the car got. The idea took the world automobile industry by storm. He was in a bind—either he could counter the news reports or produce the car at the cost he had reportedly committed to. As a man whose refrain is 'never quit' and 'never do the expected', he got down to do what the world thought was impossible. But in choosing not to contradict the press reports on the Nano's cost, he